she stood in the stands that day holding a poster that read 'Wonder Women of India—Go India Go!'

## THE LONG AND WINDING ROAD

It took the Indian women's cricket team nearly half a century to get here. On the way were familiar hurdles—patriarchy, gender bias, organisational apathy and lack of money, facilities and, most importantly, self-belief. "There were male cricketers who said women should not play cricket but be in the kitchen," recalls Diana Edulji, the 69-year-old veteran cricketer who was part of the first women's cricket team in 1974. Nearly all families faced taunts sending their daughters into a sport traditionally seen as a male preserve—"*Ladki hai, kahan bhej rahe ho*" being a common refrain. In the small towns and villages that the girls came from, hanging out with the boys wasn't deemed appropriate.

In Moga, Punjab, it would take Harmanpreet till Class 10 to understand what comments like "she's too grown-up to play with boys" actually meant. Shafali in Rohtak, Haryana, would disguise herself as a boy so that she could get coaching.

***"...The success of the latest @ICC Women's @CricketWorldCup is a testament to so many who have been working openly and behind the scenes to see this growth and evolution materialise"***

**— JAY SHAH,** *Chairman, ICC, on X*



GETTY IMAGES

### Smriti Mandhana |29|

**Innings: 9; Runs: 434; Average: 54.25**

**By her own lofty standards, ICC's ODI Cricketer of the Year for 2024 and the highest paid Women's Premier League player only had a 'decent' tournament. That means still scoring 434 runs—second only to the tally of South Africa's Laura Wolvaardt—which included a typically graceful, and crucial, century in what was a do-or-die league stage match against New Zealand and 50s against Australia and England. The poster girl for Indian women's cricket from Sangli, Maharashtra, whose #18 jerseys were ubiquitous at the DY Patil Stadium, is the most followed female cricketer on social media (13.2 million Instagram followers and counting) and is poised to be the future leader of the squad.**



PTI




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